

Chapter 9: Crossing the Line

The restaurant felt different after Isabella.

Not because anything had changed.

But because Jenny couldn't stop thinking about it.

She wiped down tables that were already clean.

Checked orders twice.

Moved through her shift on autopilot.

But her mind kept drifting.

"You're no one important."

The words replayed again.

And again.

Jenny pressed her lips together.

"Idiot," she muttered under her breath.

Bao leaned over the counter.

"Who's an idiot?"

"No one."

"That sounded personal."

Jenny ignored him.

Then the bell above the entrance rang.

She didn't look up immediately.

She already knew.

Austin Blackwood walked in.

Same time.

Same pace.

Same table.

But today, something felt heavier.

Jenny took a breath and walked over.

"Same as usual?" she asked.

"Yes."

No hesitation.

No small talk.

But his eyes lingered on her face longer than normal.

Jenny noticed.

She hated that she noticed.

She turned away quickly.

Halfway back to the kitchen, Madam Chen stopped her.

"Table seven," she said quietly.

Jenny frowned.

"I just served him."

"I know."

"Then why—"

"He asked for you specifically."

Jenny froze.

Again.

"That's becoming a habit," she said.

Madam Chen raised an eyebrow.

"It already is."

Jenny grabbed the tray again.

"Of course it is."

When she returned, Austin was watching the street outside.

Not the menu.

Not his tea.

The street.

Jenny placed the bowl down a little too carefully.

"You're early today," she said.

"I was nearby."

"That's what you always say."

He looked at her.

"Do you not believe me?"

Jenny shrugged.

"I think you plan your 'nearby' very well."

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

But it faded quickly.

His expression turned thoughtful instead.

"You've been thinking," he said.

Jenny blinked.

"I always think."

"Not like this."

She crossed her arms.

"Are you diagnosing me now?"

"I notice patterns."

Jenny sighed.

"Stop saying that."

Austin leaned back slightly.

"You're upset."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"I'm working."

"You're distracted."

Jenny stopped.

Set the tray down harder than intended.

"Why do you care?"

Silence.

Not uncomfortable.

But loaded.

Austin studied her.

Like he was deciding whether to answer honestly.

Then he said,

"I don't know."

That answer made her pause.

She wasn't expecting that.

Not from him.

Not from anyone like him.

Jenny frowned slightly.

"That's not a real answer."

"It's the only one I have."

A beat.

Jenny looked away first.

Bad habit.

Because every time she looked at him too long lately...

She felt something shift.

Something she didn't have a name for yet.

Behind them, Bao whispered,

"Ohhh, tension."

Jenny shot him a look.

He immediately pretended to clean a spoon.

Austin ignored him completely.

Instead, he said,

"You didn't ask about her."

Jenny stiffened slightly.

"Your ex-wife?"

"Yes."

"I didn't think it was my business."

A pause.

Then Austin said quietly,

"It wasn't."

That should have ended it.

But it didn't.

Jenny hesitated.

Then asked anyway.

"Are you still... involved with her?"

Austin's gaze sharpened slightly.

"No."

Quick.

Clean.

Final.

But his tone changed after that.

Lower.

More controlled.

"She appears when she wants to remind me of something."

Jenny frowned.

"What?"

"That I used to be easier to understand."

Jenny tilted her head.

"And now?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said,

"Now I'm not."

Something about that sentence felt heavy.

Not arrogant.

Not proud.

Just... tired.

Jenny sat across from him without thinking.

Then immediately regretted it.

Austin noticed.

"You don't usually sit."

"I don't usually care," she said quickly.

That made him almost smile again.

Jenny noticed something else.

He looked less sharp today.

Not weaker.

Just... more human.

She didn't know why that bothered her more than his arrogance.

"You're different today," she said.

Austin leaned forward slightly.

"How?"

"Quieter."

A pause.

"I have work."

"You always have work."

"Yes."

Jenny studied him.

Then said softly,

"Not like this."

That made him stop.

For a second.

Just a second.

Outside, the restaurant buzzed.

But inside their small corner of space...

Everything slowed.

Austin finally said,

"You notice more than you should."

Jenny shrugged.

"You started it."

A faint exhale from him.

Almost a laugh.

Almost.

Then he looked at her properly.

Not as a customer.

Not as a trader.

But as something else he hadn't defined yet.

"You're becoming a habit," he said.

Jenny's heartbeat stuttered slightly.

"That's not a good thing."

"I didn't say it was."

A pause.

Jenny stood quickly.

Too quickly.

"Finish your food."

She turned to leave.

But Austin's voice stopped her.

"Jenny."

She froze.

Not turning.

"Yes?"

A beat.

"Be careful."

That confused her.

"Of what?"

Silence.

Then—

"Me."

Jenny turned back slowly.

But he was already looking away.

Like he had said too much.

And for the first time...

Jenny wondered if she had been walking into something she didn't fully understand.

Or something she might not be able to walk out of.